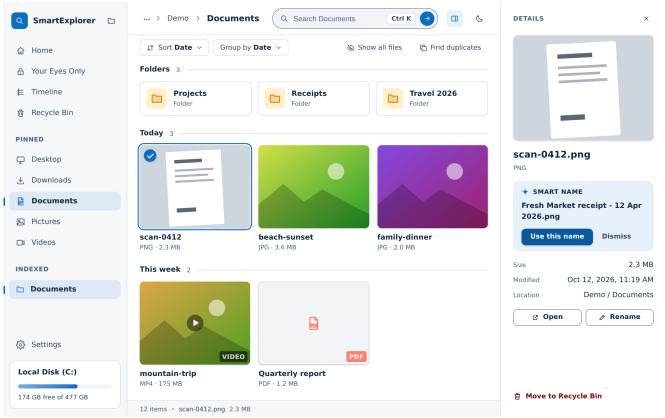
SmartExplorer

A file explorer that understands what is inside your files, and keeps it all on your own computer.

Every computer ships with a file explorer that works the way file systems did decades ago: you remember which folder something is in, or what you named it. SmartExplorer keeps the familiar look and adds the part that is missing. You can type what you remember ("PDFs that mention the Johnson contract", "photos from last winter", "a picture of a bag") and get the matching files, even when the name says nothing. The reading, text recognition and image understanding all happen locally, so no file leaves the machine.



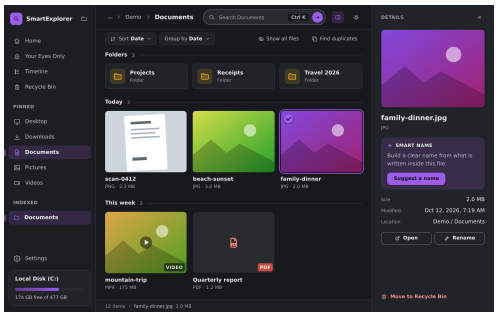
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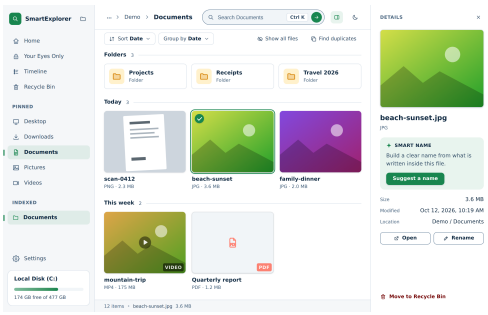
per week spent searching for information, on average, in a 2026 Slite survey of just over 100 knowledge workers (a vendor survey, so treat it as an indicator, not a census).

0 files

are uploaded anywhere. Indexing, OCR and image search run on the user's own PC.

Screenshot: the redesigned interface, white theme, with a file selected and the details panel open (demo files).





The same app in the dark theme with a purple accent, and in the white theme with green. Theme and accent colour are chosen in Settings.

The problem

People now keep thousands of documents, screenshots, scans and photos, and still find them the same way their parents did: open folders until something looks right. The built-in search helps when you remember a word that was indexed, but it does not cover everything people actually have. A photographed receipt, a scanned letter or a screenshot has text in it that a file name never reflects, and a photo of a beach is called IMG_6154. The result is lost time, duplicate copies saved "just in case", and sensitive documents left in Downloads.

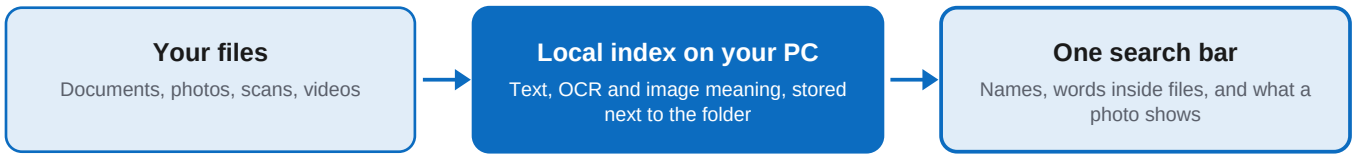
Microsoft has recognised the same gap. In January 2025 it began previewing search that finds files by describing them, such as "bridge at sunset", but only on Copilot+ PCs, which need a 40+ TOPS neural processor (NPU). Many computers in use today do not have one. SmartExplorer delivers overlapping capabilities, plus duplicate cleanup and an encrypted vault, on ordinary Windows hardware.

SmartExplorer compared with a standard file explorer

"Standard" here means Windows File Explorer with its built-in search. Rows describe the shipped SmartExplorer build.

Capability	Standard file explorer	SmartExplorer
Find by name	Yes	Yes, in the same search bar
Find words inside files	Indexes file properties and the contents of known text-based formats; coverage depends on indexing settings	Reads text inside PDFs, Word documents and text files, and ranks matches by how much of the query they satisfy
Find text inside photos and scans	Not part of standard Windows indexing	OCR reads screenshots, scans and photographed documents so their text becomes searchable
Find by what a photo shows	Only on Copilot+ PCs with a 40+ TOPS NPU (Microsoft preview, 2025)	Works on ordinary Windows PCs: search "bag" and get a photo of a bag named IMG_6154
Plain-language queries	Only through the Copilot+ semantic search above	Understands phrases like "last winter" or "PDFs that mention the contract" (dates plus text plus image content)
Naming files	You rename by hand; names are not suggested from content	Suggests a readable name from the words found inside the file, and numbers look-alikes (name, name-2, name-3)
Changing file formats	Not built in; needs other programs or websites	Right-click Convert to: PDF to Word or text, photo to PDF or Word, CSV to Excel; always a new file, original untouched
Duplicates	None built in	Finds exact copies, look-alike photos and near-identical documents saved in different formats
Browsing	Folder by folder	Also a Timeline of every file, newest first, plus gentle reminders about folders untouched for years
Sensitive files	Left where they are	"Your Eyes Only" vault: files with card, SSN or similar numbers are detected and moved into AES-256 encrypted storage
Details and personal style	Preview and details panes; follows the Windows light or dark mode and system accent colour	Details panel with a preview, size, date, location and a one-click Smart name; white or dark theme and any accent colour chosen in the app, with button text kept readable
Quick preview and storage	Preview pane; storage in Settings	Space bar Quick Look for images, video, PDFs and text; a storage chart inside the explorer
Where the intelligence runs	Local indexing; AI search needs special hardware	Entirely local. One model download on first use, then no cloud involved

How it works



Browsing a folder is instant and needs no setup. Indexing is optional and per folder: it extracts text, reads text out of images, and computes a numeric fingerprint of what each photo shows, then stores everything in a small database beside that folder. Searches run against that database.

Features in depth

The comparison table is the short version. This section explains what each feature does, in plain terms, and why it exists. Everything below is built into the current Windows version.

1. Finding things

One search bar for names, words and pictures

The same box searches file names, the words inside documents (PDF, Word, text) and the text read out of photos and scans by optical character recognition (OCR). It also searches by what a photo shows: an image model turns every picture into a numeric fingerprint of its meaning, so typing "bike" finds bikes even when the file is called IMG_6154 and contains no text.

Plain-language queries

Queries can mix time, content and text in one sentence: "photos of my dog from last winter" or "PDFs that mention the Johnson contract". The app reads season and date phrases as filters, drops filler words, and combines the rest into one search across every folder you have indexed.

Strict by design

Text matches are scored by how much of the query a file actually satisfies, and anything below a calibrated bar is left out. On a real library of over 1,100 files, a search for invoices of $20 dropped from over 200 loosely related results to the four genuine ones. Image matching is statistical: tight, but not perfect.

Find similar, from any file

Right-click an indexed file to see everything related to it. For a photo, that is visually similar pictures. For a document, it is files that share the same distinctive words, weighted so that common boilerplate does not make two unrelated files look alike.

2. Naming and converting files

Smart naming

Screenshots, scans and downloads usually arrive with useless names. Smart naming proposes a short, readable name built from the words the app already read inside the file, for example turning a screenshot of a match ticket into a name that says what it is. It keeps the original extension, capitalises the first letter, and caps the length. When several look-alike files would get the same name, they are numbered in order: the first keeps the plain name, the next become name-2, name-3 and so on, so nothing collides.



Illustrative example of the format. The words come from the text found inside the file.

Two details matter here. The suggestion costs nothing extra to compute, because it reuses text the index already holds, so it appears instantly and works offline. And when no name can be built, the app says why. If a scanned file has no readable text because the OCR component is not installed, it tells you that, instead of offering a made-up name.

Convert to, with the original kept

Right-click a file to convert it. A PDF can become a Word document or plain text; a photo can become a PDF or a Word file; a CSV or tab-separated text file can become an Excel workbook. A PDF that has real text keeps its layout, tables and images in the Word version. A PDF that is only a scanned picture is read by OCR so the Word file contains real, editable words rather than a picture of them. Every conversion writes a new file beside the original, so a result you do not like never costs you the source.

Moving, compressing and renaming

Drag files onto any folder tile, sidebar entry or breadcrumb segment to move them. Right-click to compress files or folders to a ZIP, or to extract one. If a rename fails because another program has the file open, the error names that program instead of showing a raw system code.

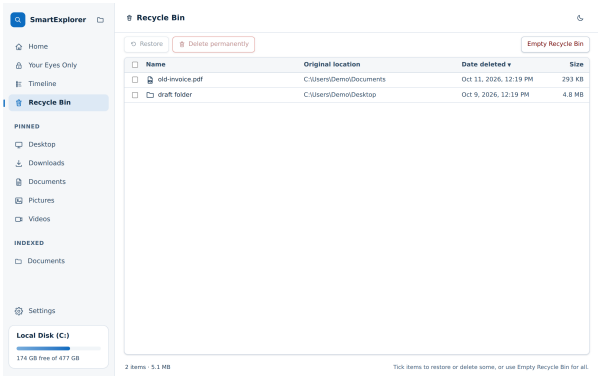
3. Cleaning up

Duplicate finder, in three kinds

The finder catches exact copies, photos that look the same but differ in bytes (a resized or re-saved image), and documents that are essentially the same text saved in different formats, such as a letter exported as both PDF and Word. Documents are compared by distinctive wording and by the numbers in them, because two forms from the same template differ only in their figures. Matches are grouped with a similarity score and the choice of what to delete stays with the person.

Storage chart

Click the disk bar at the bottom of the sidebar to see what is using space, folder by folder, largest first. Each row shows its exact name and size as text, with a bar sized against the biggest item, and you can drill into any folder. It scans one level at a time and warms the next level in the background so drilling feels immediate.



Screenshot with demo items.

Recycle Bin screen

Lists everything you deleted, with where it came from, when and how large. Tick items to restore them to their original place, or to delete just those permanently. A separate Empty Recycle Bin button clears everything. Both delete actions ask for confirmation and say they cannot be undone, and the screen can only act on items that are really in the bin.

4. A clean, personal interface

A cleaner look, built to be familiar

The interface was redesigned to look like a modern file explorer and then go further: a pure white page or a calm charcoal dark mode, rounded cards for folders and files, a quiet sidebar with a Settings entry and the disk meter, and clear headings with a count and a thin rule for each group of files. Every file card shows what it is and how big it is in one short line (for example "PDF . 1.2 MB"), and folders appear first as their own cards.

Search, sort and group in the toolbar

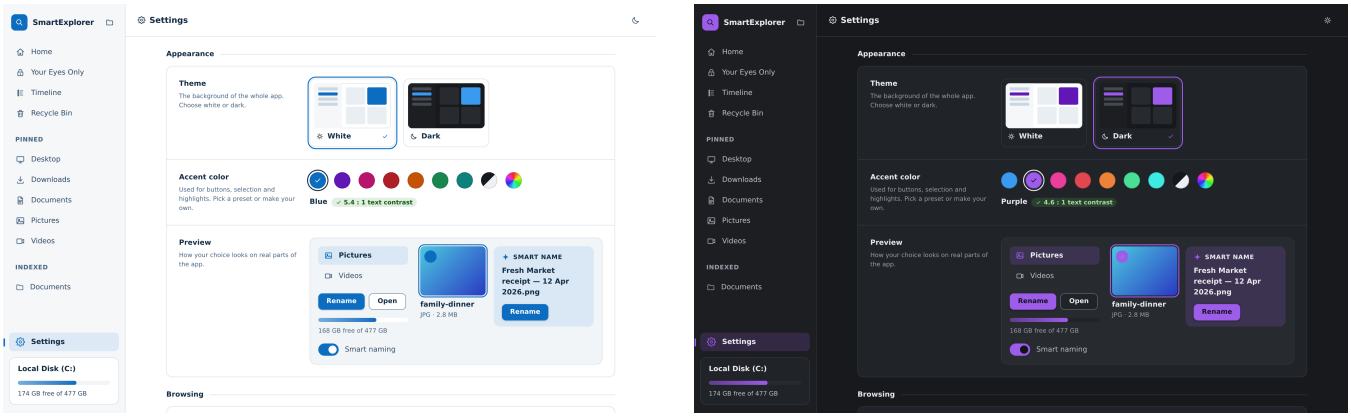
The search box sits in the toolbar as a rounded pill with a Ctrl+K shortcut that jumps straight to it from anywhere, and a round arrow button to run the search. Under it, Sort and Group by chips order the files by date modified, name or size (largest first), and group them by date or show them ungrouped as Folders and Files. The choices are remembered.

Details panel with Smart name

Select a file and a side panel shows a large preview, the name and type, size, last-changed date and location, with Open, Rename and Move to Recycle Bin buttons. For images and scans it also offers a Smart name card: press once and it proposes a readable name built from the text inside the file, which you can accept with one click or dismiss. Select several files and the panel shows how many and their total size. The panel can be hidden from the toolbar, and it steps aside automatically in a small window.

Settings: your theme, your colour

A Settings page lets each person choose white or dark for the whole app and an accent colour for buttons, selection and highlights: eight presets (blue, purple, pink, red, orange, green, teal, black and white) or a custom colour from a slider. The app checks the contrast for every choice, so the text on buttons always stays readable, and the page shows the result live on a small preview. The same page sets thumbnail size (small, medium or large) and whether file extensions are shown. Choices are remembered between sessions.



Settings in the white theme with the default blue, and in the dark theme with a purple accent (demo data).

5. Browsing and remembering

Home, Timeline and Memories

Home gives quick access to your main folders and the files you opened recently. Timeline shows every indexed file of every type in one newest-first scroll, like a photo app, with date headings and filters for photos, videos and documents. Memories adds at most three calm reminders, such as a folder nothing has changed in for two years. Each can be dismissed for 90 days, or the feature switched off. Dates are file modified times, so the wording says "last changed", never "last opened".

Quick Look and video previews

Select a file and press the space bar for an instant preview of images, video, PDFs (with page turning) and text, including the text of Word files. Arrow keys move to the next file. Hovering a video plays a silent 15-second preview, and folders of large photos load from small cached thumbnails so scrolling stays smooth.

An index that keeps itself current

While a folder is open, the app watches it. If a file is added, edited or removed, even by another program, the index updates a moment after the changes settle. Re-checking an unchanged folder is nearly free because only new or changed files are processed, and that work is spread over several workers.

6. Protecting sensitive files

Your Eyes Only

While indexing, the app looks for card numbers, social security numbers, bank routing numbers and private keys, using checksums and nearby keywords so that ordinary numbers are not flagged. Once the vault is set up, a flagged file is moved into encrypted storage (AES-256-GCM) and disappears from its folder, with no pop-up and no list of what was found. You can also drag any file or folder in yourself. The vault key is protected by your Windows sign-in password, or a short PIN if the account has none, and opening or restoring a file always asks again, so someone at an already unlocked laptop still cannot read vaulted contents.

Why this matters

File search has to change

The folder-and-filename model was built when a person had a few hundred files. Today the average person's problem is not storage, it is recall. If a computer cannot find a document from what you remember about it, the person pays that cost every week. The survey figure on the first page (3.2 hours a week) is small in sample but consistent with everyday experience, and it is time lost on the most basic job a computer does.

Private, local AI is the right design

Personal files hold the most sensitive data a person has: IDs, statements, contracts, family photos. Sending them to a cloud service to make them searchable is a poor trade. SmartExplorer proves the alternative works: recognition and image understanding run on the user's own machine, which also means it works offline and costs nothing per search. Microsoft's own direction supports this: its new Windows search runs offline on the device. The open question is who brings it to the many PCs that lack a special chip.

Where computers are heading

The operating system is moving from "navigate to your files" to "ask for your files". Search, preview, organise and protect are becoming one experience, driven by models that sit on the device. A file explorer built around that idea from the start, rather than a search box added to an old design, is positioned for that shift. SmartExplorer already combines the pieces: content search, image search, duplicate cleanup, a time-based view, and an encrypted vault.

Accessibility and productivity

People who do not organise folders neatly, who are new to computers, or who struggle with remembering file names are the ones the folder model serves worst. Describing what you want in your own words lowers that barrier. For everyone else it removes the small, constant friction of digging: fewer duplicates, faster retrieval, and sensitive files that protect themselves.

What you get today

- **Available now:** search by name, words, text in photos and picture content; plain-language queries; Find similar; smart naming; file conversion; moving, ZIP and renaming; three kinds of duplicate finding; storage chart; Recycle Bin screen; Home, Timeline and Memories; Quick Look and video previews; a self-updating index; and the Your Eyes Only vault. The interface has a redesigned white and dark look, a details panel with Smart name, Sort and Group by, a Ctrl+K search shortcut, and a Settings page for theme, accent colour, thumbnail size and file extensions.
- **Honest limits:** this is an early, Windows-first build that has so far been tested mainly on the builder's own library. Image search is statistical, so an occasional unrelated photo can still appear. The Windows-password path of the vault needs more real-world testing. Only the folder that is open updates its index on its own. A first-run model download needs internet once. The redesigned interface is new: it has been checked with automated browser tests and demo data, and still needs wider testing on real Windows machines.

Sources

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- winhelponline.com, "How to Search the Contents of Any File Type Using Windows Search": default indexing covers file properties and known text-based contents.
- SmartExplorer project documentation (progress doc and README): all SmartExplorer capabilities described here.